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**W**hen Anantjeet Singh Naruka's Olympic journey ended in Châteauroux, he headed to Paris to try to distract himself from what had just happened. Partnering with Maheshwari Chauhan, he had fallen agonisingly short, missing the podium in the skeet mixed team event by just one point.

Far from finding any relief, Naruka found his mood only soured in the French capital. "I had these big tears in my eyes. I had come so close to a medal, but ultimately I had to go back with nothing. I'd constantly be thinking about which shots I could have made," he reflects.

While other Indian shooters who competed at the Olympics took a break upon returning home, Naruka couldn't stay away from his home range in Jaipur, as thoughts of the Olympics followed him to the ISSF World Cup Final in

New Delhi. Despite winning a bronze in the men's individual skeet, defeating former Olympic medallists Jesper Hansen and Lee Meng Yuan, Naruka says memories of Châteauroux keep haunting him. "I'll be preparing to take a shot, and suddenly it will cross my mind that the moment is almost the same as one of the moments in the bronze medal match in Châteauroux where I missed a shot I should have made. It's not going to change until the Los Angeles Olympics, where I will actually have a chance to make things right," he says.

Indeed, just months after Paris 2024, Naruka is already setting his sights on the 2028 Games. He's not the only shooter with this mindset.

Although their motivations may differ from Naruka's — driven by a sense of redemption — Deepali Deshpande, former chief coach of the Indian team, asserts that the goal for every shooter remains the Los Angeles Games.

"Realistically, we are in the 2028 Olympic cycle. For some shooters, this has already begun with the 2024 ISSF World Cup Final. For others, the cycle will start with the National Championships in November and December. Even for some shooters who aren't competing in either — double Olympic medallist Manu Bhaker plans to return to action next year — the focus will be on Los Angeles. They are taking their time to complete their rehabilitation, which they probably won't have the chance to do closer to the Olympics."

There is much to be optimistic about. After years of underperformance at the Olympics, Indian shooting delivered its best performance, winning three medals at the 2024 Games. The bench strength in shooting has also been steadily growing, with participation in National Championships increasing significantly. Last year's shooting Nationals saw a surge, with 4,343

